

# Motoring

## Last drive: Jaguar's V8-powered F-Type

We say goodbye to a British icon, and the mighty V8 engine that powers it. By Nile Bijoux.

The drive home from a day at the track is usually a quiet one, exhausted from all the wind and G-forces. It's where most of us would like to be cosied up in something big and comfy, but during our recent trip to Britain, Jaguar let us take ourselves back to the hotel after our experience in an F-Type. Which would usually be both extremely cool and a bit uncomfortable, but this time the vibes were bittersweet.

That's because the F-Type is on its way out, and with it will go the mighty AJ-V8, which has served in various Jaguar Land Rover products since the mid-1990s. The 5.0-litre used here was introduced in 2009 with an all-new engine block and plenty of modern tech like direct injection and continuously variable intake/exhaust camshaft timing.

It's one of my personal favourite engines, here producing a tasty 423kW/700Nm in supercharged R 75 form, and a noise that will be exceedingly difficult to match in years going forward, multi-million-dollar hypercars aside. The British Library even immortalised the V8's sound ahead of it ceasing production.

Yeah, it's not as loud as the first generation of F-Types were, thanks to European noise emission laws which seem to be hell-bent on removing fun from cars (though, to be fair those early ones were very close to too loud), but with the pipes opened up that savage bellow is absolutely still there. Plant your foot and let those four exhaust pipes sing. Even in quiet mode the engine is still hugely pleasing to listen to. The transmission doesn't slam through the gears like dual-clutches or other high-performance automatics might, but it's still snappy when you need it to be.

The engine is smooth too. Almost disarmingly so. Letting the revs climb feels like wafting through a big bowl of light, beautiful meringue, but really fast. The car will crack 100kph in 3.7 seconds according to official figures.

Well, up until the rear end starts getting a bit loose, which can happen when peeling out from a junction. The all-wheel drive system is definitely rear-biased, but if things get really spicy it'll recruit the fronts to pull everything together. At speed, the F-Type is just gorgeous, 10 years of chassis development resulting in a sports car that notches corners like it was born to.

Which, of course, it was, and the thought made the return drive even more bittersweet. In fact, back in June the final F-Type ever was built, 50 years to the day since the last Jaguar E-Type drove off the production line.

Both sports cars are convertibles, in Giola Green with a black roof and a Tan Windsor leather interior, and both will live in the official Jaguar Heritage collection. In terms of production numbers, the F-Type won with 87,731 units built versus 72,528 E-types.

Yeah, Jaguar will probably make another sports car and it'll be fast, but at this stage it will be electric. I'm not saying EVs can't be fun, Porsche's Taycan and Hyundai's Ioniq 5 N have shown they absolutely can be, but that AJ engine just can't be replaced by volts.

Make no mistake, I'm keen to see what Jaguar will do with the new generation of powertrains. Its experience in Formula E will likely bring some serious performance chops to whatever it comes up with ... as long as it doesn't bring back the E-Type badge. I don't think it will but we've seen other brands play fast and loose with heritage names (looking at you, Ford) so it's not entirely out of the question. I-Type would work though.

Whatever the case, you can be assured the successor will look the absolute business. Jaguar has always had superb styling, and the F-Type is no different. This facelifted version wasn't designed

by Ian Callum, but the original was. While Callum no longer works for the iconic British manufacturer, he's still there as a design consultant, and you can bet he would have had input into the 2019 refresh. It looks so good, with narrow but clean headlights, nostrils on the bonnet, an elegant swept roofline, and those awesome new-age tail lights. It even looks good in matte black.

I know I'm waxing a lot here so I'll be a bit less biased. The rear visibility is pretty crap, the infotainment system is certainly showing its age now, and it absolutely drinks petrol.

But if all of that doesn't really bother you, there are a few F-Types remaining in New Zealand, asking \$193,000 each. A bargain, considering they're P575 R models, and would give a lot of Porsche 911s trouble ... Not to mention deafen their drivers. Or you could get the really special F-Type ZP Edition, which is a cool \$300,000.



Above: The interior is as luxurious as you would like. Left: There's not all that much to see under the bonnet, but that's one of the best V8 engines ever made.



Jaguar's mighty F-Type P575 R is headed out to pasture. DAVID SHEPHERD

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